**** 🌊 *Te Tahi-o-Te-Rā: The Guardian of Ōtara*

A Children's Book Inspired by the Pūrākau of Ngāti Ngahere**

Nā Te Kāhautu Maxwell — retold in story form for tamariki and rangatahi

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PAGE 1 — The Valley of Ōtara

In the quiet valley of Ōtara, where mist curls like soft korowai around the hills, there lived a taniwha named **Te Tahi-o-Te-Rā**.
His home was a hidden cave beneath the shimmering waters, a place known to the people as **Te Ana-o-Te Tahi**.

The children of the valley loved to swim near the cave—
but only when the water was clear.

For everyone knew:
when the water glowed gold like koura, Te Tahi had returned, and it was time to leave the river in peace.

PAGE 2 — Feeding the Guardian

The kuia of Ngāti Ngahere would walk to the water's edge carrying small baskets of kai.

They would toss the food gently into the cave's mouth.

"Noho ora, e Te Tahi," they whispered.
Be well, Te Tahi.

Some said it was a gift.
Some said it was a sign of respect.
And some said it was simply the way things had always been.

PAGE 3 — Te Tahi's Lineage

Te Tahi-o-Te-Rā was no ordinary being.
He was a **mokopuna of Toroa**, the great rangatira of the Mātaatua waka,
and the son of **Ruaihona**.

He grew to become a **tohunga of immense power**—
a healer, a protector,
and sometimes… someone to fear.

PAGE 4 — The Sacred Rock

Near his home stood a tall and jagged rock,
rising high above the water like a guardian watching over the valley.

This was **Te Toka-a-Houmea**.

Harakeke grew from its sides,
made sacred by Te Tahi's rituals.
It was here he performed karakia,
here he offered prayers to ancient atua,
here he held the weight of his mana.

PAGE 5 — Fear Among His People

But as Te Tahi grew older,
his mana grew even stronger.

And sometimes, when people do not understand great power,
fear begins to grow too.

Quiet meetings were held.
Whispers travelled in the night.
Until the people reached a hard decision…

They must leave Te Tahi behind.

PAGE 6 — The Journey to Whakaari

One summer day, the iwi prepared to travel to **Whakaari**,
the island of steaming cliffs and nesting tītī.

They loaded their waka with kai and precious water,
and then they invited Te Tahi to join them
—to lead the karakia for a plentiful harvest.

Trusting them,
he accepted.

PAGE 7 — Left Alone

On Whakaari, Te Tahi completed the rituals.
The people scattered across the island to gather tītī,
while the old tohunga rested in the warm sun.

But when he awoke…

everyone was gone.

The waka.
The voices.
The people he trusted.
All of them.

Te Tahi-o-Te-Rā had been abandoned.

PAGE 8 — Calling the Sea

Standing alone on the shore,
Te Tahi lifted his hands to the sky.

He called upon **Tangaroa**,
upon the taniwha of the deep,
upon the ancient creatures of the ocean.

His voice rolled across the waves like thunder.

And from the darkness of the sea rose a mighty figure—
Tūtarakauika, the chief of whales.

PAGE 9 — The Great Journey Home

Tūtarakauika glided toward the shore,
his massive body breaking through the waves.

Te Tahi climbed onto his back.
With a powerful sweep of his tail,
the great whale turned toward **Whakatāne**.

They travelled fast—
so fast that the sea frothed behind them
and the red hulls of the people's waka could be seen
drifting far in the distance.

PAGE 10 — The Unspoken Lesson

When Te Tahi returned home,
his people were there.
The men looked at him with wide eyes,
their mouths silent,
their hearts shamed.

Te Tahi did not shout.
He did not punish.

He simply said:

"Waiho mā te whakamā e patu."
Let shame be the punishment.

And the people understood.

PAGE 11 — Becoming the Guardian of the Sea

When Te Tahi-o-Te-Rā eventually left this world,
his wairua returned to the ocean.

There he transformed into a taniwha —
a **marakihau**,
a guardian of the deep waters.

His home in Ōtara,
in his underwater cave,
and he travels the vast Moana-a-Toi.

PAGE 12 — Te Tahi Today

Even today, the people say:

If one of his descendants is lost at sea,
if the waves grow rough,
if danger approaches—
Te Tahi or Tūtarakauika will come.

They will lift the person from the ocean,
carry them safely to shore,
and protect them just as they once protected the tohunga of old.

** 🌊 ***Te Tahi-o-Te-Rā: Te Kaitiaki o Ōtara***

He Pukapuka Tamariki i Takea mai i te Pūrākau a Ngāti Ngahere**

Nā Te Kāhautu Maxwell — kua whakahāngai kia pānui ai te hunga tamariki me te rangatahi

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WHĀRANGI 1 — Te Whārua o Ōtara

Kei te whārua mātao o Ōtara, e kōpere ana te kohu ki ngā puke, e noho ana tētahi taniwha, ko **Te Tahi-o-Te-Rā** tōna ingoa.
Ko tana kāinga he ana huna kei raro tonu i te wai, e kīia ana ko **Te Ana-o-Te Tahi**.

He maha ngā tamariki i kaukau i taua wāhi—
engari mēnā he mā te wai anake.

I mōhiotia whānuitia:
ki te huri koura te wai, kua hoki mai a Te Tahi, ā, me waiho rā te awa kia tau.

WHĀRANGI 2 — Te Whāngai i te Kaitiaki

Ka haere ngā kuia o Ngāti Ngahere ki te taha o te wai.
He kete kai kei ō rātou ringaringa.

Ka whiua e rātou ngā kai ki roto ki te ana,
me te kōrero māhaki:

"Haere tonu tō ora, e Te Tahi."

He mea tuku aroha pea.
He tohu whakanuia pea.
He tikanga tuku iho e kore nei e memeha.

WHĀRANGI 3 — Te Whakapapa o Te Tahi

Ehara a Te Tahi-o-Te-Rā i te mea noa iho.
He **mokopuna ia nā Toroa**, te rangatira o te waka Mātaatua,
ā, he tama nā **Ruaihona**.

I tipu ake hei **tohunga whai mana**,
he kaiārahi, he kaiwhakaora,
ā i ētahi wā… he tangata i matatakina.

WHĀRANGI 4 — Te Toka Tapu

Kei tōna kāinga tētahi toka nunui,
e tū whakarakei ana ki runga ake i te wai.

Ko **Te Toka-a-Houmea** tōna ingoa.

I tipu ake te harakeke i runga i taua toka,
he tapu te harakeke nei,
i te mea he wāhanga nui ki ngā tikanga o Te Tahi.

I reira ia ka tū karakia,
ka tuku whakahere ki ngā atua o nehe,
ā, ka pupuri i tōna mana.

WHĀRANGI 5 — Ka Tipu te Mataku

I te pakeketanga o Te Tahi,
ka kaha ake hoki tōna mana.

Ā, mēnā ka kore te iwi e mārama ki te mana nui o tētahi,
ka tipu te mataku.

Ka hui huna te iwi.
Ka tere ngā kōrero i te pō.
Ā, ka tau te whakatau taumaha…

Me waiho a Te Tahi ki muri.

WHĀRANGI 6 — Te Haerenga ki Whakaari

I tētahi raumati, ka whakaritea te haerenga ki **Whakaari**,
te moutere kōuaua e rere ai te korohū.

Ka utautatia ngā waka ki te kai me te wai,
ā, ka tono atu rātou ki a Te Tahi
kia haere hei kaiwhakahaere karakia mō te hopu tītī.

Me te pono o tōna ngākau,
ka whakaae ia.

WHĀRANGI 7 — Ka Mahue Tētahi Tangata

I Whakaari, ka oti ngā karakia a Te Tahi.
Ka marara te iwi ki ngā kokonga o te moutere ki te tiki tītī,
ā, ka whakatā te koroua i te mahana o te rā.

Engari i tōna oho—

kua ngaro katoa te iwi.

Kua ngaro ngā waka.
Kua ngaro ngā reo.
Kua ngaro ngā tāngata i arohaina e ia.
Kua mahue ia ki muri.

WHĀRANGI 8 — Te Karanga ki te Moana

Ka tū a Te Tahi ki te tahataha o te moana,
ka hiki ake ōna ringa ki te rangi.

Ka karakia ki **a Tangaroa**,
ki ngā taniwha o te wai,
ki ngā atua o te moana nui.

Ka pā te reo o te tohunga ki te rāwhiti me te rāwhiti,
pērā i te whatitiri.

Ka pāhunu ake i te moana tētahi mea nunui—
ko Tūtarakauika, te rangatira o ngā tohorā.

WHĀRANGI 9 — Te Hokinga Nui

Ka kau mai a Tūtarakauika ki uta,
e kī ana te ao i te kaha o tana ngaru.

Ka piki a Te Tahi ki runga i tōna tuarā.
Ka tahuri te tohorā, ka anga tonu ki **Whakatāne**.

Ka tere rawa te haerenga—
ka koropupū te wai ki muri,

ka kitea hoki ngā waka whero o te iwi
e memeha atu ana ki tua.

WHĀRANGI 10 — Te Akoranga Nui

I te taenga mai ki tōna kāinga,
kāore te iwi i kōrero.
Ka tūtaki ngā kanohi,
ka pā te whakamā.

Kāore a Te Tahi i hamumu,
kāore ia i riri.

Ka mea noa iho ia:

“Waiho mā te whakamā e patu.”

Ā, ka mārama te iwi.

WHĀRANGI 11 — Te Wairua e Hoki Ana ki te Moana

I te matenga o Te Tahi-o-Te-Rā,
ka hoki tōna wairua ki te moana nui.

Ka whakakētia ia hei taniwha ano—
hei **marakihau**,
hei kaitiaki o te Moana-a-Toi.

Kei Ōtara tonu tōna rua huna,
ā, ka haereere ia i te moana whānui.

WHĀRANGI 12 — Te Tahi i ēnei rā

Ā mohoa noa nei e kī ana te iwi:

Ki te raru tētahi uri i te moana,
ki te huri ngā ngaru,
ki te tata te mate—

ka haere mai a Te Tahi,
ka haere mai rānei a Tūtarakauika.

Ka hiki mai rātou i te tangata,
ka whakahoki ora ki uta,
pērā tonu i tā rātou mahi i ngā rā onamata.

**** 🌟 TE MUTUNGA**

— engari ka noho tonu te wairua o Te Tahi-o-Te-Rā.**